The Weight of Building: Three Founders, Three Breaking Points

Teaching Case (HBS-style) — written for this course

Prepared for: TUM Entrepreneurship Course: Prototyping Entrepreneurial Ideas for AI

Decision Point: Three founders, three moments of crisis. What should have been done differently?

How this case ties into Module 11

The vignettes are composites, but you will recognize people in this room — possibly yourself in week 11 of a revenue sprint. Work three connections: (1) **Idea 1 — energy, not time:** for each vignette, name which of the four dimensions (body, emotions, mind, purpose) broke first; it's rarely the one people manage. (2) **Idea 2 — the data says both things:** founders carry elevated mental-health risk (Freeman 2015) AND report high meaning (Stephan 2018) — hold both, don't romanticize either. (3) **The workshop bridge:** vignette 3 is deliberately set in a course like this one; your Energy Audit protocol today is the countermeasure you design before you need it.

Introduction

The mythology of the startup founder is powerful: The visionary who sleeps at their desk. The obsessive who sacrifices everything for their dream. The sole person with enough conviction to bet their future on an idea.

The mythology is also dangerous.

The statistics are grim:

- In a study of 242 entrepreneurs and 93 demographically matched comparison participants, 30% of entrepreneurs reported lifetime depression — about 2× the comparison group (Freeman et al., 2015)

- Roughly half (49%) of the entrepreneurs in that same study reported at least one lifetime mental health condition (Freeman et al., 2015)
- 72% of founders report that building a startup has affected their mental health (Startup Snapshot 2023 — an industry survey, not peer-reviewed research)
- Founder burnout and suicide are the dark secret of the tech industry
- Most founders delay seeking help until crisis mode (therapy, coaching, medical intervention)

At the same time, the research is not one-note: entrepreneurs report both higher strain and higher engagement and meaning in their work than employees — the "stress-satisfaction paradox" (Stephan, 2018).

This case study does not profile specific named individuals or their private health details. Instead, it presents **three fictional vignettes based on common patterns** in founder mental health crises. The people in these vignettes are composites; the situations are real patterns. Each vignette represents a different type of founder and a different warning sign.

The goal is not to be depressing, but to **normalize** these challenges and build a "wellbeing protocol" that other founders can recognize and use before they hit crisis.

Background: Why Founders Break

The Psychological Pressures Unique to Founding

Founding a company creates a psychological storm unlike most other experiences:

1. Identity Fusion Most founders don't separate their self-worth from their company's performance. Their company isn't something they do — it's who they are. When the company struggles, it feels like a personal failure.

A founder might rationally know: "This setback is normal. 90% of startups fail. This doesn't mean I'm a bad person."

But they feel: "I've failed. I am a failure."

2. Constant Uncertainty - Will this fundraising round close? - Will customers adopt our product? - Did we build the right thing? - Is our team actually good? - Are we burning cash too fast? - Will the market change before we can adapt?

Most employees have clarity: "My job is to do X. I'm evaluated on X." Founders have permanent ambiguity.

3. Total Ownership When something goes wrong, there's no one to blame. You hired the wrong person. You built the wrong product. You made the wrong bet. You didn't work hard enough.

This is simultaneously motivating and crushing.

4. The Loneliness of Visibility As founder, you're the CEO, CFO, main salesperson, product strategist, and therapist to your team. You can't show weakness. You must project confidence, even when terrified.

5. All-or-Nothing Thinking Founding companies encourages binary thinking: this will be a massive success (unicorn) or a failure. But most of startup life is lived in the middle — slow growth, uncertainty, incremental progress.

This binary thinking is motivating but also makes every setback feel catastrophic.

The Industry Context

By 2023-2024, founder mental health was beginning to be discussed openly, but stigma remained:

- Many founders hid their struggles (and hid them well)
- VCs rarely asked about founder wellbeing in investment meetings
- The "grind culture" was still celebrated in media and within the community
- Seeking help (therapy, coaching) was often seen as a sign of weakness
- Few accelerators or incubators had mental health support built in

---

The Situation

Vignette 1: The Technical Founder at Breaking Point

Name: Alex (co-founder, age 28)

Company: ChainLedger (blockchain-based supply chain tracking)

Timeline: - Founded: January 2023 - Seed fundraising: Raised €800k from angels and 2 VCs in June 2023 - Team size (now): 7 people - Runway: 14 months

The Situation:

Three months ago, Alex's co-founder and CEO announced he was leaving the company. He was burned out. The reason he gave: "I need to focus on my mental health. I can't do this anymore."

Alex respected the decision. But he also panicked.

Now Alex was wearing three hats: CTO (technical product), acting interim CEO (fundraising, investor relations), and de facto therapist to the team (who were confused and worried).

His daily reality: - **Mornings:** Technical debugging sessions with the 4-person engineering team. Blockchain integrations were fragile. One wallet library had a memory leak that Alex could spend hours optimizing or could just document and move on. Alex couldn't move on. He'd sit for 3-4 hours trying to optimize. - **Midday:** Responding to investor emails. The €800k was funding a 14-month runway, but with the CEO departure, investors were nervous. They wanted weekly updates on "stabilization." Alex had no template for this email. He'd spend an hour crafting updates that were simultaneously honest about challenges and confident about the future. - **Afternoons:** Recruiting. They needed a new CEO or a head of operations. Alex was conducting interviews even though he hated interviews. He was bad at them. He'd second-guess every hiring decision. - **Evenings:** Engineering work until midnight because the team was understaffed. - **Late nights:** Anxiety. Alex would wake up at 3 AM with a racing mind: "What if we can't find a CEO? What if investors pull out? What if we fail?"

The Symptoms: - Alex's GitHub commit history showed he was still pushing code until 2-3 AM, several nights per week - His Slack messages became increasingly brief and sometimes curt (people interpreted this as frustration, though Alex was just exhausted) - He missed a 1:1 with a junior engineer, then forgot they'd rescheduled. He missed the rescheduled meeting too. - His apartment was getting messier. Laundry piled up. He'd order takeout every night because cooking felt impossible. - He stopped answering his family's calls. His mom texted: "Are you okay? You never call anymore." - His one close friend suggested getting coffee. Alex declined: "Too busy." They stopped asking. - He started researching "burnout" and "depression" late at night, which only increased his anxiety.

The Breaking Point:

In a technical design review with the engineering team, a junior engineer (Priya) pointed out a flaw in Alex's architecture proposal.

Normally, Alex would have engaged: "Let me think through this." Or, if wrong, "Good catch. Let's redesign."

Instead, Alex said: "That's not a real issue. You're overthinking."

Priya felt dismissed. (She was right; there was a real issue.) She didn't push back, but her body language changed.

After the meeting, Alex felt immediate guilt. He went to apologize, but the interaction revealed something to Alex: **he wasn't thinking clearly anymore.**

That night, Alex sat at his laptop and realized he couldn't write a simple function. Not because it was hard, but because his mind felt like it was moving through mud. He'd written the same lines of code three times and each time forgot what he'd just written.

He closed his laptop at 8 PM (early for him) and just sat in his apartment, thinking: "I'm breaking."

He didn't tell anyone. Not the team. Not his mom. Not his investor. He thought: "If I admit this, the company falls apart."

The Dilemma:

Now, a week later, Alex faces a choice:

1. **Keep pushing.** The situation is temporary. The team needs him. Investors need his confidence. In a few months, things will stabilize. He can handle this. (The rational story he tells himself.)
2. **Tell someone.** Tell his investors that he's struggling. Tell the team. Bring in an interim CEO or COO now (which looks like a loss of control, which looks like weakness, which might cause the company to collapse anyway).
3. **Take time off.** But leaving the company untended for a week or a month feels like abandonment.
4. **Quit.** The company would survive without him. The engineering team is good. But if he quits, it looks like he couldn't handle the pressure. It looks like failure. And it probably is the end of ChainLedger.

The Central Question for Alex:

When does "pushing through" become self-destructive? And more importantly, who decides — you or someone else recognizing the warning signs?

Vignette 2: The CEO Who Hit Success and Lost Meaning

Name: Marta (CEO and founder, age 35)

Company: FreshRoute (AI-powered route optimization for delivery companies)

Timeline: - Founded: March 2019 - Series A: €3M (May 2021) - Series B: €12M (September 2022) - Current ARR: €1.2M - Team size: 28 people

The Situation:

By any metric, FreshRoute is successful.

The company grew from 0 to €1.2M ARR in 4 years. Customers include 3 major logistics companies in Germany. Growth is 20% quarter-over-quarter. The Series B was oversubscribed; they turned away investors.

Marta has done everything right: hired a strong team, built product customers wanted, raised the capital, managed the fundraising rounds.

And yet, for the past 6 months, she's been waking up with a sense of dread.

The Symptoms:

- **Identity collapse:** Marta's life for 5 years was: build FreshRoute, convince people to join, raise capital, optimize the product. Those milestones happened. Now what? The company doesn't need her to "convince people to join" anymore (they get inbound). It doesn't need her to "optimize the product" (she hired a VP of Product). It doesn't need her to raise capital (the Series B gives them 3 years of runway).

Marta is now a CEO, which mostly means: hiring, strategy, board meetings, investor relations. Important work, but not the work that excited her when she started.

- **Disconnection from the product:** Marta hasn't written code in 3 years. She doesn't know what the current product roadmap is beyond the headline. She uses FreshRoute as a customer might, not as a builder would. The product has evolved and Marta hasn't evolved with it.
- **Guilt about success:** Marta grew up in a working-class family. She was the first in her family to go to university. Now she has a comfortable life, €1.2M company (her equity is probably worth €10M if the company exits), and the "problems" she deals with are like: "Should we take this Series C opportunity?" This feels obscene compared to her parents' lives.
- **Imposter syndrome:** Every board meeting, Marta feels like a fraud. The board members (successful founders, experienced investors) seem so competent and clear. Marta feels like she's faking it. She thinks: "If they knew I don't actually understand the SaaS metrics they're discussing, they'd replace me."
- **Anxiety about the future:** The route optimization market is getting crowded. Larger companies (Google, logistics giants) could build something similar. What if FreshRoute's growth stalls? What if customers churn? What if we raise Series C and can't deliver the growth numbers we promised?

- **Emotional distance from the team:** Marta used to know every employee personally. Now there are 28 people and she's in board meetings 30% of her time. She feels like she barely knows the 10 people who joined in the last year. When team members come to her with problems, she feels impatient: "Can't your manager handle this?"

The Breaking Point:

Marta's CFO suggested she'd be a good candidate for "board duty" — sitting on the board of other companies while still CEO of FreshRoute. It's a way to give back, build your network, and stay involved in the ecosystem.

Marta's honest reaction: "I don't want to sit on anyone else's board. I don't even want to be on FreshRoute's board anymore."

This thought scared her. It meant: "I don't want to do this job."

But she can't leave. She has obligations to employees, investors, customers. She can't just quit because she's not feeling fulfilled.

So she's stuck: a successful CEO of a company she's ambivalent about, unable to be honest about it, working toward a Series C she's not sure she believes in.

The Dilemma:

Marta faces choices that have no good answers:

1. **Keep going, pretending to be enthusiastic.** Push toward Series C, continue scaling. Maybe in a few years, the company will be big enough to exit, and she'll have a large payday. But she'll have spent 7-10 years doing work that doesn't fulfill her.
2. **Be honest with the board.** Tell them: "I'm losing enthusiasm for this. I don't think I'm the right CEO for the next phase." But this likely means she'll be replaced. Her board has fiduciary duty to the company, not to her happiness.
3. **Step down and hand off to a new CEO.** But she founded the company. People expect her to believe in it. Stepping down looks like giving up.
4. **Pivot the company.** The market is getting crowded. What if FreshRoute became something different? But this would feel like failure (she built something successful and now she's abandoning it).
5. **Take a sabbatical.** Tell the board: "I need 3 months off to think about what I want." But 3 months off while being CEO is not really off. Crises don't pause.

The Central Question for Marta:

How much of your life should you spend on something that no longer fulfills you, even if it's successful?

And: When is the right time to admit that you've achieved what you wanted to achieve, and it wasn't enough?

Vignette 3: The First-Time Founder Failing Publicly

Name: Jordan (founder, age 26)

Company: LearnFlow (AI tutor for high school students)

Timeline: - Founded: January 2024 - Timeframe: This is current day - Context: Part of TUM's entrepreneurship program

The Situation:

Jordan is a student in your class. They founded LearnFlow as a side project 3 months ago, with the goal of building an AI tutor that felt like talking to a human teacher (not a robot).

For the first 2 months, Jordan was energized. Building the first prototype was exciting. Getting beta feedback from 10 friends who tested LearnFlow felt validating.

But in month 3, something shifted.

Jordan realized that: - The AI model they trained wasn't good enough at understanding nuanced student questions - Other competitors (expensive tutoring startups + free ChatGPT-based alternatives) were flooding the market - Teachers and schools were skeptical about AI tutors - Convincing parents to pay for an AI tutor (not a human) was harder than expected - The unit economics were bad (it cost more to operate LearnFlow than they could charge)

Yesterday, Jordan decided to announce (in a Discord for the class) that LearnFlow is pausing. They're not going to continue. They're going back to focusing on schoolwork.

Jordan expected... nothing, really. Or maybe a few "thanks for sharing" messages.

Instead:

- 15 classmates responded in the thread, many saying things like "I thought this was cool" or "I was going to try it next semester"
- A professor replied: "Great learning experience. Let's discuss what you'd do differently next time."

- Jordan's co-founder (a friend from class) texted privately: "Are you okay? You seem depressed about this."

The Symptoms:

Jordan has been: - Avoiding the Discord channel where they announced the pause - Not going to class because they don't want to see classmates - Telling people: "Yeah, it didn't work out, but that's normal" (true, but said in a tone that suggests shame, not learning) - Catastrophizing: "I'm bad at building things. Everyone else in class is shipping products. I failed. I should probably just drop out." - Sleeping more (10-11 hours per night, even though they're usually energized) - Comparing themselves to other student founders: "They got to 100 users in a month. I could only get 10. I'm behind. I'm not a real founder."

The Breaking Point:

Today, a friend texted Jordan: "Hey, you want to get coffee and talk about LearnFlow?"

Jordan's first instinct: "No, I don't want to relive this failure."

But then Jordan paused and recognized: "I'm ashamed. Even though I know that failing on a project is normal, I'm feeling shame like I've done something morally wrong."

This recognition scared Jordan. It made clear that **the problem isn't LearnFlow's failure (normal, healthy learning), the problem is Jordan's response to the failure (shame, isolation, negative self-talk).**

The Dilemma:

Jordan faces a choice that might seem trivial compared to Alex or Marta, but carries real weight:

1. **Brush it off and move on.** Start the next project. Treat this as a learning experience. But without processing the shame, Jordan might internalize: "I failed once, I'll probably fail again, so why try?"
2. **Talk about it.** Go get coffee. Be honest about feeling ashamed. Ask for help processing it. But this requires vulnerability with a friend, which is scary.
3. **Lean into the failure narrative.** Tell people: "Yeah, LearnFlow didn't work. Here are the mistakes I made." Turn it into a public learning. But this might amplify the shame (making it even more public).
4. **Avoid and isolate.** Keep the shame private. Don't talk to the friend. Don't go to class. Hope the feeling goes away. (This is the most likely path, and the most dangerous one.)

The Central Question for Jordan:

How do you separate your self-worth from your project's success?

And: When is the right time to ask for help, rather than suffer alone?

The Common Patterns

Across all three vignettes, certain patterns emerge:

Pattern 1: The Silence

All three founders suffered alone before reaching a breaking point: - Alex didn't tell anyone he was drowning - Marta didn't tell her board she'd lost meaning in the work - Jordan didn't ask for help processing the shame

The reason: they believed that admitting struggle would somehow cause their company/life to collapse.

But the opposite is true: the longer they suffer in silence, the more likely they are to make bad decisions, burn out, or self-destruct.

Pattern 2: Identity Fusion

All three founders fused their identity with their company or project: - Alex thought: "If I can't hold the company together, I'm a failure." - Marta thought: "I'm the CEO, so my worth is defined by how well the company grows." - Jordan thought: "I'm a founder, so my worth is defined by my project's success."

The antidote: separating your identity from your company. You are not your company. Your worth is not determined by your company's success or failure.

Pattern 3: Binary Thinking

All three founders thought in extremes: - Alex: "Either I solve all these problems, or everything collapses." - Marta: "Either I stay as CEO and push toward Series C, or I'm a quitter." - Jordan: "Either LearnFlow becomes a successful startup, or I'm a failure."

The reality: most things are not binary. You can get help and still be the CEO. You can pause a project and still be a founder. You can struggle and still be capable.

Pattern 4: Delayed Help-Seeking

All three waited for crisis to ask for help: - Alex waited until he couldn't focus anymore - Marta waited until she realized she didn't want to continue - Jordan waited until they felt ashamed enough to notice the shame

The pattern: founders are terrible at asking for help preemptively. They ask for help only when they've hit a wall.

Pattern 5: The Myth of "Pushing Through"

All three founders believed (or half-believed) in the mythology of the tough founder who pushes through. This mythology is dangerous because: - It suggests that struggling is weakness - It suggests that asking for help is failure - It suggests that the only legitimate founders are the ones who don't struggle - It's false: most successful founders struggle, and many seek help

---

The Decision Point

You are reading this case study because you are either:

1. A potential founder considering whether to start a company
2. A current founder who might recognize yourself in one of these vignettes
3. A friend or family member of a founder
4. An investor or board member overseeing founders

Regardless, here is the decision before you:

If You Are A Potential Founder

Decision: Should you found a company, given the mental health risks?

The answer is: **It depends. But only if you have a plan for your wellbeing.**

Founding a company is hard. It will challenge you mentally. The question is not whether to avoid the challenge, but how to navigate it with eyes open.

If You Are A Current Founder

Decision: What is your "wellbeing protocol" before you hit crisis?

Consider these questions:

1. **What does your support system look like?** Who can you talk to honestly (without them benefiting from your company's performance or failure)? Do you have a therapist? A coach? A founder peer group? A mentor?
2. **How will you separate your identity from your company?** What are you outside of being a founder? What would you still do if your company failed?
3. **What are your early warning signs?** For you specifically, what symptoms indicate you're approaching burnout? (Sleeping more? Social withdrawal? Losing focus? Increased irritability?)
4. **When is it okay to ask for help?** Not when you're at a breaking point. Now. Before you need it.
5. **What does success actually look like to you?** Is it a unicorn exit? €1M ARR? Building a company you'd want to work at? Building something that doesn't consume your life? Be honest about what success means to you, not what the media or investors say it should mean.

If You Are A Friend or Family Member

Decision: How do you support someone founding a company without enabling them to suffer?

Consider:

1. **Notice the signs.** If your founder friend is sleeping more, canceling plans, or venting about the same stress repeatedly, they might be struggling.
2. **Ask directly.** "I've noticed you seem stressed. Are you okay? Do you want to talk?" Not a judgement, just an invitation.
3. **Offer practical help.** "Do you want me to pick up groceries?" "Want to take a walk?" Sometimes founders need someone to do small things so they can breathe.
4. **Don't collude with their isolation.** If they're canceling plans, keep inviting them. If they're not answering calls, keep calling.
5. **Know your limits.** You can't fix their company. You can't save them from bad decisions. But you can be present and remind them they're not alone.

If You Are An Investor or Board Member

Decision: How do you create a board culture that supports founder wellbeing?

Consider:

1. **Ask about it.** Just like you'd ask about unit economics or customer churn, ask about founder wellbeing. "How are you doing? Are you sleeping? Do you have support outside of the company?"
2. **Make it safe to be honest.** Don't punish founders for admitting struggle. If a founder says "I'm burning out," the response should be "What do you need to change?" not "You need to work harder."
3. **Model it.** As an investor or board member, be honest about your own struggles. Create a culture where humanity is visible.
4. **Be willing to make changes.** If a founder is burning out from being too many roles, help them hire. If they're burned out from certain board dynamics, change how board meetings work.
5. **Know the difference between "tough love" and cruelty.** Pushing a founder is sometimes right. But there's a line, and many investors don't see it until the founder has a breakdown.

Exhibits

Exhibit A: Founder Mental Health Statistics

Statistic	Source
30% of entrepreneurs reported lifetime depression — about 2× a demographically matched comparison group	Freeman et al. (2015), "Are Entrepreneurs 'Touched with Fire'?" — 242 entrepreneurs vs. 93 comparison participants
29% of entrepreneurs reported lifetime ADHD	Freeman et al. (2015)
12% reported substance use conditions; 11% reported bipolar spectrum conditions	Freeman et al. (2015)
Roughly half (49%) of entrepreneurs reported at least one lifetime mental health condition	Freeman et al. (2015)
72% of founders report that building a startup has affected their mental health	Startup Snapshot (2023) — industry survey, not peer-reviewed research
Entrepreneurs report both higher strain and higher engagement and meaning in their work — the "stress-satisfaction paradox"	Stephan (2018), Academy of Management Perspectives review

Exhibit B: Common Warning Signs (By Timing)

When	Sign	What It Means
Month 1-3	Extreme energy, reduced sleep	Normal startup mode, but track if sustained
Month 6	Occasional social withdrawal	Increasing stress, still manageable
Month 12	Regular sleep loss, irritability	Approaching danger zone
Month 18+	Apathy about the company, isolation, rumination	Crisis approaching
Crisis	Inability to focus, emotional flatness, thoughts of quitting	Immediate intervention needed

Exhibit C: Intervention Strategies (Early to Late)

Strategy	When to Use	What It Looks Like
Prevention	Before problems emerge	Regular sleep, exercise, social connection, therapy
Early intervention	Noticing warning signs	Talk to friend/mentor, adjust schedule, consider coaching
Mid-stage	Active stress without crisis	Time off, bring in help, redistribute responsibilities
Crisis intervention	Breakdown happening	Medical care, extended leave, co-CEO or interim CEO

Exhibit D: The Wellbeing Protocol (Template)

Every founder should have:

1. **A support network outside the company:** therapist, coach, trusted friends/family, founder peer group
2. **Regular check-ins:** weekly with someone not involved in the company
3. **Non-negotiable health practices:** sleep, exercise, eating, social connection
4. **Early warning system:** list your personal warning signs and action steps
5. **Emergency plan:** who to call if you hit crisis? How will the company continue if you take leave?
6. **Definition of success:** what does “winning” actually mean to you (not to investors, not to media, but to you)?
7. **Exit strategy:** when is it okay to leave? Under what circumstances would you step back?

Exhibit E: Reframing the Narratives

Old Narrative	New Narrative	Why It Matters
"Pushing through is strength"	"Knowing when to pause is wisdom"	Pushing through crisis often leads to worse outcomes
"Struggling is weakness"	"Struggling is part of the process"	Normalizes the reality of founding
"I have to do everything"	"I need to delegate and get help"	Delegation scales, solo effort doesn't
"If I admit I'm struggling, the company will fail"	"If I don't admit I'm struggling, I will fail"	Your wellbeing determines company outcomes
"Success means unicorn exit"	"Success means building something sustainable with a life I want"	Different definition for different people

Questions for Class Discussion

1. **The Alex scenario:** At what point should Alex tell his investors and team that he's struggling? If he tells them, should he step down immediately or ask for help getting an interim CEO?
2. **The Marta scenario:** Is it a form of failure if you build a successful company but find it unfulfilling? What would count as "success" for Marta?
3. **The Jordan scenario:** Jordan is still a student, so there's less at stake than Alex or Marta. But is the shame they feel disproportionate to the actual risk? How do you separate self-worth from project success?
4. **Your own warning signs:** What would be the first sign, for you personally, that you're approaching burnout? How would you notice it?
5. **The support network question:** Most founders don't have adequate support. Why? Is it cultural (founders don't talk about these things)? Logistical (expensive to get therapy)? Psychological (admitting need feels weak)?
6. **The investor/board question:** How would you, as an investor, want founders to signal that they're struggling? What would make it safe for them to be honest?

7. **The prevention question:** If you were designing an accelerator or incubator, how would you build mental health support in from day one, rather than reacting to crises?

Resources (For Students in Real Struggle)

If you recognize yourself in any of these vignettes, this case is not just academic. Here are actual resources:

- **Therapy/counseling:** TUM likely has counseling services. Look for "Studentische Beratung" or contact your student services
- **Crisis support:** In Germany, Telefonseelsorge offers 24/7 phone support (0800-1110111 or 0800-1110222, free)
- **Founder-specific support:** Oracles Foundation (founders.org) has mental health resources; Founder Collective publishes on mental health
- **Talk to someone:** A friend, family member, mentor, professor. You don't have to figure this out alone

---

Epilogue Notes for Instructors

This case is designed to normalize founder mental health challenges, not to scare students away from founding. The goal is:

1. Help students recognize early warning signs (in themselves and others)
2. Reduce stigma around mental health in the founding community
3. Encourage proactive support-seeking, not reactive crisis management
4. Make it clear that founder wellbeing is not separate from business success — it's foundational to it

The vignettes are fictional but based on real patterns. During class discussion, you might share (if appropriate) that mental health challenges are common, that seeking help is strength, and that the best founders build support systems early.

Sources

- Freeman, M.A., et al. (2015). “Are Entrepreneurs ‘Touched with Fire’?” Study of 242 entrepreneurs and 93 demographically matched comparison participants; source of the lifetime prevalence figures (depression 30%, ADHD 29%, substance use conditions 12%, bipolar spectrum 11%, at least one condition 49%).
- Stephan, U. (2018). “Entrepreneurs’ Mental Health and Well-Being: A Review and Research Agenda.” Academy of Management Perspectives; peer-reviewed review; source of the stress-satisfaction paradox finding.
- Startup Snapshot (2023). Industry survey of founders (not peer-reviewed); source of the figure that 72% of founders report building a startup has affected their mental health.

Teaching case written for this course. Vignettes are composites; all statistics are cited to their sources above.